

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

The Christian Spiritual Reset

*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

Pastor Richmond Kobe

FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

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Contact: info@faithfulpathcommunity.com

found, and it ends with an elder brother who resents the welcome. We will not deal with him today. But it is worth knowing that the running father is not only private comfort; he is Jesus' picture of God's joy in receiving the lost, told to people who thought such joy was a scandal.

Most people arrive at a retreat the way the younger son arrives home: with a speech prepared.

In the far country, after reaching the end of himself, he formed the speech he intended to give his father. "Father, I have sinned against heaven and before you. I am no longer worthy to be called your son. Treat me as one of your hired servants." Parts of the speech are deeply honest: he has sinned, and he is no longer worthy to claim his former place. But it also contains a plan for managing his return by negotiating a new position in the household. He proposes coming back not as a son who must be received, but as a worker who can earn a place. He appears more able to imagine employment than restored relationship.

When the son finally speaks, he confesses his sin and unworthiness, but the proposed line about becoming a hired servant is never recorded. Verse 20 says that "while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and felt compassion, and ran and embraced him and kissed him." Before any negotiation can begin, the father orders the robe, the ring, the sandals, and the feast. The father is not interested in a useful son. He wants his son.

I begin the retreat here because I have watched many people come to God the way the son came home: with a plan for how to be acceptable. They arrive intending to be very disciplined, or very repentant, or very focused, so that by the end of three days they will have earned the right to be received. Some of what you wrote in your intention may have that shape. Some of your

resistance in the week before may have been the fear that you would not manage the speech.

The passage says something simpler. Before the son can negotiate his status, the father moves toward him in compassion. The initiative belongs to grace. Whatever you have prepared to say, the welcome does not depend on it.

That is what "come as you are" means. You come as you are because there is no other way to come. You do not come because your present condition is unimportant, but because transformation begins with being received truthfully rather than presenting a repaired version of yourself. Jesus' own invitation in **Matthew 11:28** is addressed to "all who labor and are heavy laden," which is a description, not a qualification. The tired, distracted, doubtful, resentful, numb version of you is the one that is invited. There is no other version available to bring.

This first session does not require you to manufacture a particular feeling, complete a spiritual inventory, or produce perfect repentance before God will receive you. If you are already aware of sin that needs confessing, you do not need to postpone it. Name it honestly. But do not imagine that the quality of your remorse purchases the Father's welcome. Repentance is a return to the God whose grace has already made return possible. Session Five will give unhurried space for the deeper kind of confession that surfaces slowly in quiet. For now, the one thing asked of you is that you arrive honestly, present as you are, before a God who has seen you coming for a long time.

Self-assessment

Answer these in your journal, briefly. This is a check-in, not a test.

1. How is your body right now? Tired, restless, tense, heavy, numb, calm? Name it without fixing it.
2. How is your mind? Racing, foggy, anxious, blank, quietly sad?
3. What speech have you prepared? In other words, what have you been planning to prove, achieve, or perform during these days so that the retreat will count?
4. Look back at your Chapter 4 check-in. Does it still describe you today? What has changed since you wrote it, if anything?

Guided prayer

Read this slowly, aloud if you have privacy, or silently. Change any words that are not yours.

Father, I am here.

That is the most honest thing I can say.

*I have come tired, and I have come with explanations,
fears, and plans for proving myself.*

I set those plans down.

I cannot earn the welcome you give by grace.

You saw me before I began this journey.

Help me receive your mercy before I try

to explain or improve myself.

Let me be honest with you during these days.

I place the outcome in your hands.

I am here.

Amen.

If the language of embrace in the passage is difficult for you, you can pray instead: "Let me know that I am welcomed and safe in your presence."

Now take the intention you wrote in Chapter 7 and read it to God, exactly as you wrote it, including the part you had not said and the line about releasing the outcome. This is the first thing you say to him on the retreat, and it does not need to be improved.

Silence

Suggested length: ten minutes. Adjust to what you can manage, as Chapter 12 described.

Anchor phrase: **"While he was still a long way off, his father saw him."** Or, if you prefer something shorter: **"I am here."**

Sit, stand, or walk slowly. When your attention drifts, return to the phrase. You are not trying to feel anything. You are letting yourself be seen.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

Take as long as you need with these. Full sentences are not required.

1. What did you notice during the silence? Thoughts, feelings, physical sensations, nothing in particular. Write it down without interpreting it.
2. The father ran. What is your honest reaction to the idea that God is not waiting for you to arrive properly, but is already moving toward you in compassion? Relief, suspicion, disbelief, indifference? Write the true answer.

3. The son planned to be a servant rather than a son. Where in your life, or your faith, have you been trying to be useful instead of being received?
4. Finish this sentence, and do not think about it too long: "The thing I most need to tell God honestly at the start of this retreat is..."

Practical exercise: setting things down

Take three or four of the index cards from Chapter 10. This exercise has two parts, and the distinction matters.

Bring into the retreat. Some of what you carried here belongs here: grief, anger, spiritual questions, shame, relationships that need prayer, and the central intention you wrote in Chapter 7. Do not seal these away. They are what the next nine sessions are for, even if you approach them gradually.

Set aside until Day 3. Other things you carried in do not need attention during the retreat: routine work tasks, non-urgent emails, shopping and errands, decisions that do not need to be made this week, problems already delegated to someone else. Write these on the cards, one item per line, as specifically as you can. If the list runs to several cards, that is normal.

When the list is complete, read it once. These are real, and they will still be real on the last day. But they are not for now. Put the cards in an envelope, seal it, and write on the front: *Not until Day 3*. Put the envelope somewhere you will not see it, in your bag or a drawer. You will reopen it during Session Ten.

One exception. The envelope is for non-urgent demands. Do not place a safety concern, a medical need, a crisis, thoughts of harming yourself, or an urgent responsibility inside and tell yourself it must wait until Day 3. Those are handled as Chapter 5 described, now.

You are not throwing anything away. You are giving yourself permission to put the ordinary demands down for three days. The father's house is a place where the pig field does not have the final word. There will be time to tell the truth about where you have been, but your failure is not the only fact about you.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. If a line feels beyond you, change "I" to "I want to believe," "I am willing to consider," or "Help me receive."

I have come as I am.

I am seen from a long way off, with compassion.

I do not have to earn these days.

During this retreat, I will practise laying down performance, and I will begin learning a different way to live when I return.

Notes

Space for anything else you want to record from this session.

Before Session Two: take a substantial break, ideally an hour or more. Follow your planned meal and medication schedule, rest if needed, and move gently if that is accessible and safe. Session Two is best begun after real time away from the page.

SESSION TWO

Be Still and Become Present

Day 1, afternoon

Before you begin

You have had a break, a meal, perhaps a walk or a sleep. Before you sit down, notice whether your mind has drifted back to the envelope. That is normal on the first afternoon. Notice it without judgement. Unless you realise that you placed an urgent safety, health, or caregiving matter inside, leave it sealed until Day 3.

Have your Bible, your journal, and your timer. This session is slower than the first, and it contains the longest silence so far. If ten minutes was your limit this morning, stay there. Nothing in this session requires more.

Central passage

Psalm 46

Read the whole psalm twice. The second time, notice how much noise there is in it before verse 10.

Teaching

"Be still, and know that I am God" is one of the most quoted lines in the Bible, and it is almost always quoted out of its setting. Read the psalm from the beginning and the setting is anything but still.